



FREE GUIDE · FOR COACHES GROWING THEIR CLIENT BASE

Marketing & Client Acquisition for Personal Trainers

A practical playbook for getting found, getting enquiries, and turning them into paying clients, without wasting hours chasing likes that don't pay the rent.

Who this guide is for

This is written for coaches who can train, but haven't cracked a reliable way to keep new enquiries coming in, whether you're just starting out, or you've been relying on word of mouth and would like that to be less of a coincidence.

There's no single channel that fills a diary on its own. This guide walks through the pieces in the order they actually matter: getting your message clear first, then owning your channels, then layering on social content, referrals, and paid ads once the foundation actually works. Skipping ahead to ads or content before the foundation is set is the most common way coaches waste money on marketing.

A NOTE ON ACCURACY

Platform features, algorithms, and advertising rules change over time, and some of what's below (Australia's Spam Act 2003, Australian Consumer Law) carries real legal obligations. Treat the specifics here as a strong starting point, then confirm current requirements with ACMA, the ACCC, or your own advisor before you rely on them.

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Every step from this guide, in one page

Know Who You're Talking To

Most marketing that doesn't work fails before a single post goes out. The channel isn't the problem: the message is too generic to make anyone stop scrolling. Before you spend time or money on any channel, get two things clear.

Pick a niche you can say out loud

"I help people get fit" describes almost every trainer in the country, so it doesn't help anyone choose you specifically. "I help busy parents fit strength training around school pickups" or "I help runners come back from injury without losing their fitness" gives a specific person a reason to think you're talking to them. A niche in your marketing doesn't mean turning other clients away; it just gives your message somewhere to land.

Write a one-line positioning statement

A simple template that forces clarity: *"I help [who] achieve [result] through [your method], without [the thing they're afraid of]."* You won't put this sentence on a billboard, but if you can't fill in all four blanks specifically, that's usually the real reason marketing hasn't been working, not the platform you chose.

NICHE YOUR MESSAGE, NOT NECESSARILY YOUR CLIENT LIST

You can market specifically to busy parents while still happily training whoever walks through the door. The niche is there to make your marketing land with someone; it isn't a rule about who you're allowed to work with.

Once you know who you're talking to, the next question is what you're actually inviting them to say yes to. That's next.

Turn Your Training Into an Offer

“Personal training sessions” is a service: open-ended, easy to compare on price, and hard to say yes to because it doesn't say what actually happens. An offer gives it shape: a name, a timeframe, and a clear idea of what's included, so a prospective client knows exactly what they'd be agreeing to.

What actually makes up an offer

- ✓ **The outcome:** the specific result it's built around, stated plainly, not a vague promise of “getting fitter.”
- ✓ **The timeframe:** a defined start and end, or a clear recurring cycle, not an open-ended arrangement.
- ✓ **The format:** 1:1, small group, or online/hybrid, whichever actually suits the outcome and the client.
- ✓ **What's included:** sessions per week, programme design, check-ins, nutrition guidance, progress tracking, spelled out, not implied.
- ✓ **One package price:** presented as a single number for the whole offer, not a per-session rate that invites negotiation.

Build an offer ladder, not one offer

A single all-or-nothing offer asks a stranger to commit hard on day one. Most sustainable PT businesses instead run a small ladder: a low-commitment entry point (a paid trial week, or a single assessment session), leading into a core offer (the main paid programme), leading into an ongoing offer once that programme ends (a monthly membership or ongoing coaching). Each rung makes the next yes easier than jumping straight to the top. If you're going solo, without a gym feeding you leads, that first rung is sometimes genuinely free training: a deliberate way to build real results, proof and referrals before you have any paying demand, not a discount you're backed into.

Name it like a product

“Tuesday 6am sessions” is a timetable slot. “12-Week Strength Reset” or “Return-to-Running Rebuild” is a product: something you can refer to the same way in every post, every enquiry reply, and every conversation, without re-explaining it from scratch each time.

A FEW EXAMPLES

A busy-parents niche might sell a “6-Week Time-Poor Strength Foundations” programme: two 30-minute sessions a week, built around school-hours availability. A returning-runner niche might sell a “Return-to-Running Rebuild”: 8 weeks, 1:1, with a physio referral built into week one. Same trainer, same skill set, different named offers, each one specific enough for the right person to recognise themselves in it.

Own Your Channels

Social platforms are rented land: the algorithm, the rules, and even the app itself can change overnight and take your reach with it. A website, a search listing, and your own client list are the three assets nobody else can switch off.

Claim your Google Business Profile

When someone searches “personal trainer near me,” the results they see first come from Google Business Profile (the free local listing tool, formerly Google My Business), not Instagram. A complete, accurate, regularly updated profile (hours, photos, service area, genuine reviews) is one of the highest-leverage, lowest-cost things a local trainer can maintain.

A simple website beats no website

It doesn't need to be elaborate: what you do, who it's for, how to get in touch or book, and a couple of real testimonials is enough. An Instagram-only presence makes a prospective client do the work of finding your contact details buried in a bio; a one-page site removes that friction and signals you're a real, established business.

Start your own list from day one

Every enquiry, trial client, and past client belongs on an email or SMS list you control, with their consent to be contacted. This is the one channel that survives an algorithm change, a hacked account, or a platform ban, and it's the cheapest way to stay in front of past clients when you have something worth telling them.

KNOW THE RULES BEFORE YOU SEND

Australia's Spam Act 2003 applies to marketing emails and texts: you need consent to contact someone (a signed-up lead or an existing client relationship counts, a cold-scraped list doesn't), the message must clearly identify your business, and it needs a working unsubscribe link that you honour promptly. These are straightforward to meet; just make sure they're in place before you send your first campaign.

Social Media Without Wasting Your Time

Social content earns trust when it's specific and consistent, not when it goes viral once. Most followers will never see most of your posts, which is exactly why repeating your core message matters more than constantly inventing new ones.

Pick three or four content pillars, and repeat them

A workable mix for most trainers: client education (how you actually assess and coach, not generic tips), behind-the-scenes or personal content (why you coach the way you do), real results with permission, and the occasional post about your business itself. Rotating through the same handful of pillars is a feature, not a rut: it's what makes your account recognisable.

Choose one primary platform

Trying to run five platforms well usually means running none of them well. Pick whichever one your specific niche audience already spends time on, get genuinely good at it, and treat any other platform as a secondary repost rather than an equal priority.

A sustainable rhythm beats a sporadic burst

Seven posts one week followed by three weeks of silence reads worse than a steady, realistic pace you can actually keep up, even if that's two or three posts a week. Plan a week or two of content in one sitting so posting doesn't depend on finding motivation each day.

CONSISTENCY COMPOUNDS, VIRALITY DOESN'T

One viral post rarely converts directly into paying clients: it mostly reaches people who were never going to book anyway. The accounts that actually convert followers into enquiries are the ones that show up with the same clear message, week after week, until it's remembered.

What to Actually Post

Pillars only help once you know what an actual post inside each one looks like. Here's what that looks like for the four from the previous page.

Client education

A 30-second form check on an exercise clients commonly get wrong, a breakdown of why you programmed a session a certain way, or a real question a client or follower asked you this week, answered publicly. The bar isn't originality; it's specificity: content that could only come from someone who actually coaches, not a generic tip anyone could repost.

Behind the scenes

Your own training, a look at how you actually build a client's week, the reason you got into coaching in the first place, or an honest day-in-the-life. This is the content that builds trust in the person behind the business, not just the service on offer.

Real results, done honestly

A specific client's story framed as their individual result rather than a promise to everyone else (see Chapter 7 on keeping this compliant), a short testimonial in the client's own words, or a genuine progress metric with the context behind it. Ask before every post that includes someone else's likeness or story.

The business itself

New availability, a programme about to open, or a milestone worth sharing. Use this pillar sparingly: it's the one your audience cares least about, so it should be the smallest slice of your total posting, not the default.

Match the idea to the format

Short-form video (Reels, TikTok, Shorts) tends to reach people who don't follow you yet: it's built for discovery. Carousels and static posts with saved-worthy information tend to perform better with people who already follow you, since they get saved and shared. Stories are the lowest-effort option for small, everyday moments that don't need a full post. None of it needs to be highly produced; clarity and consistency beat production value.

KEEP A RUNNING LIST

Every question a client or follower asks you is a ready-made post. Keep a running note of anything anyone asks you about training, form, or nutrition. You'll never run out of ideas, and it's already proof you know what you're talking about.

Referrals & Local Partnerships

Referrals are the cheapest, highest-trust source of new clients most coaches have, and the one most left entirely to chance. Turning them into an actual system, rather than something that occasionally happens on its own, is mostly about timing and making it easy.

Ask at the moment it's earned, every time

The best time to ask is right after a client notices real progress (a milestone hit, a compliment from someone in their life, a goal reached), not at a random moment disconnected from how they're feeling about the results. Build the ask into a recurring point in your client process (a 6–8 week check-in is a natural spot) rather than something you remember to do once, if at all.

Make it easy to say yes to

A client who agrees in principle to refer someone will often never get around to it unless you remove the thinking. A simple shareable link, a referral code, or a straightforward “bring a friend for a free session” offer gives them something concrete to act on instead of having to compose a message from scratch.

Partner with businesses who already see your ideal client

Local physios, chiropractors, sports stores, and cafes near your training location see the exact people who'd benefit from a PT, and they aren't competing with you for the same work. A genuine two-way relationship (you send them clients who need clinical care, they mention you to clients ready to train) costs nothing and keeps paying off long after the first conversation.

REFERRALS REWARD TRUST, NOT EFFORT

No referral system will outperform a bad experience. People refer friends because they're confident their friend will be looked after well, so the real foundation of a referral system is the quality of the coaching and service you're already delivering, not the system itself.

Paid Ads, Done Properly

Paid ads amplify what's already working: they don't fix what isn't. Running ads before your offer, response process, and booking flow work properly just means paying to find out faster that something upstream needs work.

Start small and track cost per client, not clicks

A modest weekly budget is enough to learn from. The number that actually matters is what it costs you to turn a stranger into a paying client, not impressions, likes, or even cost-per-click, which can look great while producing nobody who ever books a session.

Meta ads are usually the starting point

For a local trainer, location- and interest-based targeting on Facebook and Instagram tends to be the most accessible entry point, relatively cheap to test, and well suited to reaching people in your area. Search ads (Google) can work too, particularly for people actively searching “personal trainer [suburb],” but competitive fitness keywords in larger cities often cost more per click, so they're usually worth testing once you already have a working process, not as the very first thing you try.

A bad offer with great creative is still a bad offer

No amount of polish on the ad itself fixes a vague positioning statement or an unclear next step. If Chapter 1's positioning work isn't done yet, that's worth fixing before spending anything on ads: the creative's job is to communicate an offer clearly, not invent one.

COMMON FIRST-AD MISTAKES

Targeting too broad an audience instead of a specific niche; no single clear next step (book a call, claim a trial) for someone to take; sending traffic to a busy Instagram feed instead of a simple landing page; and judging results after two or three days instead of giving a campaign two to three weeks to gather enough data to mean anything.

Turning Enquiries Into Clients

Everything before this chapter is about generating an enquiry. What happens in the hours after someone messages you decides whether it turns into a client, and it's the stage most coaches pay the least attention to.

Reply faster than feels necessary

Someone weighing up a few trainers often books with whoever responds first and clearly, not necessarily whoever is the best fit on paper. Aim to reply the same day, ideally within a few hours: a slow reply loses people who've already moved on to someone else by the time you get back to them.

Give them one clear next step, not five options

A first reply loaded with pricing tiers, package options, and scheduling questions asks a stranger to do too much thinking. A single, low-effort next step, such as booking a free intro session or a 15-minute call, converts better than presenting the whole menu upfront.

Run a real discovery conversation before you sell

Ask about their goals, history, and constraints before talking price or programmes. It's not just a sales tactic: understanding fit properly up front is what makes the training relationship actually work once they sign up, and it reads as genuine interest rather than a pitch.

Make booking itself frictionless

A direct booking link beats a back-and-forth text thread trying to find a time that works. Every extra step between "I'm interested" and a session on the calendar is a chance for someone to lose momentum and not follow through.

EVERY ENQUIRY SHOULD LAND IN ONE PLACE YOU ACTUALLY CHECK

Instagram DMs, missed calls, a contact form, and walk-in conversations all need to funnel somewhere you reliably see and respond to, not spread across four inboxes where the fastest-fading interest is the one most likely to get missed.

Retention Is Marketing

Every hour spent finding a new client is an hour not spent keeping an existing one, and a retained client is both cheaper to keep than a new one is to find, and a more reliable source of referrals than any ad ever will be.

Collect testimonials properly, and consistently

Ask at the moments clients are genuinely pleased with their progress, not just once at the very start of your business when you're short on proof. A short written quote or a brief video, with clear permission to use it publicly, is worth more than a highlight reel of stock-photo transformations.

KEEP RESULT CLAIMS HONEST

Australian Consumer Law requires that testimonials you use be genuine and that any claim you advertise be one you can back up, and the ACCC has specifically taken action against fitness and weight-loss promoters over guaranteed-result claims. Present real client outcomes as individual results rather than promises ("this is what worked for one client, not a guarantee for everyone"), and it protects both your credibility and you legally.

Reactivate past clients before chasing new ones

A list of people who've already trained with you, liked the experience, and know how you coach is a warmer, cheaper source of bookings than a stranger who's never heard of you. A genuine, occasional check-in, not a generic blast, is often all it takes to bring someone back.

Ask about renewal before the package ends

Raising what's next while a client is still mid-programme, rather than waiting to see if they rebook on their own, is the difference between a business that retains clients on purpose and one that loses them by default.

The Marketing Checklist

Every step from this guide, in order. Print this page or keep it open while you work through the rest.

- ✓ Write a one-line positioning statement (who, result, method)
- ✓ Turn your training into a named, specific offer
- ✓ Claim and complete your Google Business Profile
- ✓ Build a simple one-page website with a clear way to get in touch
- ✓ Start collecting emails/numbers with proper consent from day one
- ✓ Confirm your marketing emails/SMS meet Spam Act requirements (sender ID + working unsubscribe)
- ✓ Choose 3–4 content pillars for social media
- ✓ Pick one primary platform and a posting rhythm you can sustain
- ✓ Build a referral ask into your regular client process
- ✓ Create an easy way for clients to refer (link, code, or bring-a-friend offer)
- ✓ Identify 2–3 local businesses for a genuine referral partnership
- ✓ Hold off on paid ads until your offer and response process work
- ✓ Set a small weekly ad budget and track cost-per-client, not just clicks
- ✓ Aim to respond to every enquiry within the same day
- ✓ Give every enquiry one clear next step, not a menu of options
- ✓ Collect testimonials consistently, with permission to use them
- ✓ Keep result claims honest: no guaranteed outcomes in your marketing
- ✓ Set a regular cadence for reactivating past clients



A note from Totality's founder

"I built Totality because I'm a personal trainer myself, and I was sick of running my business through four apps that didn't talk to each other. This guide is the advice I wish someone had handed me when I started: the practical, unglamorous stuff nobody puts in a course brochure."

Taj Donaldson, Founder & CEO, Totality · Personal Trainer

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